

FACT CHECKING GEOFFREY PULLUM'S CLAIMS ABOUT DANIEL EVERETT IN BRAZIL

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Abstract

Geoffrey K. Pullum has repeatedly made severe accusations that the linguist Daniel L. Everett suffered mistreatment in Brazil because his research on the Pirahã people and their language threatened Chomskyan theory. The present article presents a large trove of previously unavailable evidence (official Brazilian government documents, citizen information requests, interviews, etc.) that are directly relevant for assessing the claims that Everett was slandered and unjustly blocked from field research. The evidence disproves these claims, which have circulated widely in what I am designating as the Persecution Hoax. The evolution of Everett's problems with Brazil's National Foundation for Indigenous Peoples (FUNAI) is traced and found to be due to his own behavior and not to the action of Noam Chomsky or his affiliated linguists, nor to envious linguists in Brazil. Some variants of the Persecution Hoax myth, which are incompatible with the evidence and with each other, are described, along with comments. This myth is unfavorable for the development of indigenous linguistics in Brazil, as are Pullum's suggestions for fieldwork. This is discussed briefly and alternative suggestions are offered.

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1. Introduction: The accusations

As is widely known, the linguist Daniel Leonard Everett (**DLE**) published an account of the language and culture of the Pirahã people of Brazilian Amazonia in 2005 (Everett 2005) which opened a very public debate, which continues today. The linguist Geoffrey K. Pullum (**GKP**) has defended DLE stoutly, maintaining that he has been the victim of vilification, mendacity, prejudice and research obstruction. Some of GKP's statements in the last two years are as follows:

Linguists who disagreed with him did not limit themselves to presenting syntactic evidence. Rather, they published allegations that he was a liar, a charlatan, and a racist; they accused him of both scientific misconduct and illegal research activity; and they played a role in getting his applications to do further field research denied by a Brazilian government agency. (Pullum 2024a: 1)

In Brazil, the allegations started to reach further than simply positing dishonesty. Rumors were spread that for decades Everett had been working illegally, never obtaining the required permits for working in Indian areas. Denny Moore, an American linguist resident in Brazil, made forceful allegations along these lines to me in personal conversation and subsequent email (May 2019) and made further remarks on the topic in a Facebook comment in January 2024. (Pullum 2024b: 38)

Everett is not and never has been the subject of any civil suit or criminal indictment for illegal presence in an indigenous area. Yet allegations that he is a notorious lawbreaker continue to be spread by linguists in Brazil. (Pullum 2024b: 40)

He did not deserve the years of hot-tempered public allegations and insults (or the worse incidents of insult, hate mail, and shouting in his face that he does not publicly report). A sector of our field seems to have lost its moral compass over this issue.

It speaks well of Everett that never in all the years since 2005 has he responded to his tormentors with insults or abuse: he argues points of fact, but he refrains from accusing his enemies of scientific misconduct, devious motives, or self-interested mendacity. For that, and much more, we should salute him. (Pullum 2024b: 68)

Yet a vague shadow of disreputability lingers, and his career as the most important living Amazonian field linguist has been truncated by the success of his enemies in getting his field research applications denied by FUNAI.

The sole basis for this entire saga is that he stated something about sentence structure in Pirahã that conflicted with recent Chomskyan orthodoxy. That was judged sufficient reason to smear him as a racist, to spread rumors about him breaking Brazilian law, and to recommend against his doing further work on a language in which hardly any other outsider is fluent. (Pullum 2024a: 14)

GKP likens the accusations against Everett to those against the anthropologist Napoleon Chagnon:

The attack mounted by NP&R [Nevins, Pesetsky & Rodrigues], and taken up by other anti-Everett linguists, was not the worst that a social scientist ever suffered; the libeling of anthropologist Napoleon Chagnon and geneticist James Neel by Patrick Tierney (2000) was surely worse. But the trashing of Daniel Everett runs a fair second for nastiness. (Pullum 2024a: 3)

In this paper we will see the facts of DLE's case and what the parallels really are with the case of Chagnon. Accusations were made against Chagnon by a man, Patrick Tierney, who had wandered around indigenous lands in Brazil with no authorization from the federal authority, the National Foundation of Indigenous Peoples (FUNAI) and often presented a false identity. He did not have the facts of the case and was not interested in them. As the facts came out, he was exposed and discredited. He invented ideas that were, to the informed, obviously highly

improbable, for example that Chagnon's distribution of goods was the cause of Yanomami warfare.

The focus of the public discussion of the Chagnon case was on the scandalous accusations, with little interest in the situation of the Yanomami or what needed to be done for them. As in the case of the Yanomami, in the case of DLE and the Pirahã, the focus has been on the scandalous accusations, including those made by GKP above, with little mention of the situation of the Pirahã or what needs to be done for them. The reality is that their current situation is bad. An expedition of the FUNAI in 2023¹ found

- a lack of natural resources in the interior of the territory of the Pirahã because of population growth and invasions;
- a long regional history of exploitation of Pirahã labor in the production of Brazil nuts, copaiba oil and açaí, in conditions analogous to slave labor;
- exploitation in commerce, for example, exchange of a sack of Brazil nuts for a package of coffee or cachaça (120 proof rum), which is causing immense impact on the population;
- an alarming scene of children with worms, skin disease, malnourishment and malaria.

Urgent measures indicated included furnishing basic food baskets, territorial protection with emphasis on control of invasions for predatory fishing, lumbering and exploitation of groves of Brazil nut trees. A visit in 2025 found conditions temporarily improved.² The Pirahã had been subordinated to the Coordenação Regional Madeira. This was changed to the Frente de Proteção Etnoambiental (FPE) Madeira-Purus, which has more expertise with recently contacted peoples.

As happened with other indigenous groups in Brazil, long-standing problems among the Pirahã were exacerbated during the four-year Bolsonaro government, which was catastrophic for indigenous communities (and which was supported by the evangelical missionary network).

2. Finding the facts

Unfortunately, many of the facts of the DLE case in Brazil have not been investigated and shared until now. It would be difficult for GKP to do so, even if he wanted to, since he has limited knowledge of indigenous matters in Brazil, never, to my knowledge, having set foot in a native village, being outside the loop of Brazilian indigenous linguistics and having no direct experience with Brazilian institutions. He appears to have DLE as his main source of information, not looking any further. He repeats old accusations, not only about Noam Chomsky, his colleagues and former students, but also about linguists in Brazil, of which I am certainly one, as a loyal (more or less retired) scientist of the Brazilian Ministério de Ciência, Tecnologia e Inovação (MCTI).

Since my name was mentioned in GKP's accusations, I have invested some time in fact-finding about the Everett-Pirahã case in Brazil, which could have been settled some time ago with correct information. The relevant information that I have accumulated includes official documents (which are definitive in any legal proceedings), especially DLE's extensive (356 page)

¹ <https://www.gov.br/funai/pt-br/assuntos/noticias/2023/funai-realiza-visita-a-aldeias-piraha-no-rio-maici-e-propoe-criacao-de-rede-interinstitucional-para-enfrentamento-de-crise-de-seguranca-alimentar-e-saude> (03/08/2026)

² <https://www.mpf.mp.br/o-mpf/unidades/procuradoria-geral-da-republica-pgr/noticias/mpf-visita-terra-indigena-piraha-no-amazonas-para-avaliar-a-situacao-dos-indigenas-de-recente-contato> (03/08/2026)

dossier (Inquérito Civil 1.31.000.000601/2007- 75) in the Ministério Público Federal (MPF), three Solicitations of Information for the Citizen (SIC) that were made to the National Foundation of Indigenous Peoples (FUNAI) and documents from the National Council for Scientific and Technological Development (CNPq). This information was supplemented by information from people who worked on the projects of DLE, FUNAI officials, old e-mails and entries about events in the notebooks I have kept for decades. To maintain focus, for now I will only deal with DLE's relevant activities since 2004, though there are more from earlier times that are relevant--some of them quite colorful. I shall also generally leave aside technical linguistic questions such as recursion and syntax, and questions of native thought and culture. The focus is on fact finding to create a more accurate history of events, to evaluate GKP's claims that DLE has suffered mistreatment in Brazil. In the discussion of GKP's various claims, attention is given to questions relevant for the development of Brazilian indigenous linguistics, which is my principal interest.

3. The process for research authorization to enter indigenous areas in Brazil

Since questions involving legal authorization for field research in Brazil are a crucial part of the story of DLE in Brazil, these matters, which are often not understood by foreigners, will be explained, as essential background.

All prospective researchers, national or international, who wish to enter an indigenous area must submit an application for authorization to the FUNAI, via its Studies and Research Department, the Assessoria de Acompanhamento de Estudos e Pesquisas (AAEP), also called the Coordenação Geral de Estudos e Pesquisas (CGEP) in the past.³ The applicant needs to submit a description of the proposed research and its timetable, as well as his curriculum vitae, proof of institutional affiliation, identification, vaccination record and medical statement. Currently clearance by an ethics board is also required. The project is then sent to the National Council for Scientific and Technological Development (CNPq) to be evaluated for scientific merit, contribution to Brazilian scientific development and contribution to the native community. The CNPq evaluation process involves judgements by ad hoc reviewers from the Brazilian scientific community. The applicant receives copies of the reviews and can appeal them if he wishes. The finished CNPq report, if positive, goes to the FUNAI, which sends the proposal to the regional FUNAI office, which consults the indigenous community to ascertain their acceptance of the proposal. If all is accepted, the researcher is granted a written authorization, which he can carry with him, giving him cooperation from regional FUNAI personnel and protection from any harassment from suspicious locals. At the end of the authorization period, the researcher must report on his activities and what he has seen in the field, making any recommendations for measures for the community. He also sends copies of all works produced to the FUNAI.

For foreigners who do not have permanent visas, the CNPq application is through its sector of scientific expeditions (AEX).⁴ If the application is approved by the CNPq and the FUNAI, a research visa is emitted by the Ministério de Relações Exteriores, and the authorization to enter the appropriate indigenous areas is emitted by the FUNAI. Foreign applicants must have a Brazilian counterpart researcher and a cooperating Brazilian institution. One of the criteria for CNPq project evaluations for foreigners is the contribution that the research will make to national scientific development and to the indigenous community. The purpose of these requirements is to curtail the *Grab-The-Data-And-Run* behavior that some foreigners think is natural. Such behavior, outside of the legal requirements and collaboration obligations, is

³ <https://www.gov.br/funai/pt-br/atuacao/terras-indigenas/ingresso-em-terra-indigena> (03/08/2026)

⁴ <https://memoria.cnpq.br/in-english-summary> (03/08/2026)

designated **GTDAR** here. In this way, Brazilian scientific development is furthered by the research, in cooperation with Brazilian scientists and institutions, in return for access to the excellent research opportunities that exist in the indigenous areas of Brazil. Researchers who find these procedures to be too onerous should work in some other country, one that is less intent on its own scientific development.

This system selects for the most competent, responsible researchers who are interested in furthering Brazilian scientific development, not GTDAR. I have had the good fortune to sponsor various foreign linguists who have conducted excellent research, often receiving awards, as well as contributing to Brazilian scientific development through training Brazilian students and interaction with Brazilian institutions and carrying out practical projects for native communities.

4. DLE's lack of research authorization

The case of DLE is completely outside this pattern. To check the facts about DLE's research authorization I made a Citizen Information Request (SIC) to the FUNAI in 2023. According to the information furnished by the FUNAI, in response to this SIC, DLE has not had a valid research authorization for an indigenous area since 1979, only a journalistic authorization in 2009, to accompany his film project:⁵

Prezado Senhor, Cumprimentando-o cordialmente, e em resposta a sua demanda informamos que foram concedidas as seguintes Autorizações em nome do pesquisador Daniel Leonard Everett, conforme segue abaixo: Autorização Para Pesquisa Científica em Área Indígena nº 13/PRES de 02/03/1979; Autorização Para Pesquisa Científica em Área Indígena nº 34/PRES de 10/07/1979; e Autorização Para Ingresso em Terra Indígena nº (ilegível)/CGEP/2009 - 29/06/2009. Ressaltamos que o Sistema de Informações Eletrônico/SEI, foi implantado na Fundação em 2017, e em consulta no sistema não localizamos na Assessoria de Acompanhamento aos Estudos e Pesquisa, nenhuma solicitação em aberto para ingresso em terras indígenas em nome do referido pesquisador. Sem mais para o momento, colocamo-nos à disposição para eventuais esclarecimentos. Atenciosamente, SIC/Couvid/Ouvi sic@funai.gov.br (61) 3247 6306

*[Dear Sir, Cordial Greetings, and in response to your request, we inform you that the following authorizations have been granted in the name of researcher Daniel Leonard Everett, as follows: Authorization for Scientific Research in Indigenous Area No. 13/PRES dated March 2, 1979; Authorization for Scientific Research in Indigenous Area No. 34/PRES dated July 10, 1979; and Authorization for Entry into Indigenous Land No. (illegible)/CGEP/2009 - June 29, 2009. We emphasize that the Electronic Information System/SEI was implemented at the Foundation in 2017, and upon consulting the system, we did not find any open requests for entry into Indigenous lands in the name of the aforementioned researcher in the Study and Research Monitoring Office. Without further ado, we remain at your disposal for any clarifications. Sincerely, SIC/Couvid/Ouvi sic@funai.gov.br (61) 3247 6306]*⁶

⁵ FUNAI's response to the Citizen's Request for Information, protocol number 08198.041120/2023/11, authored by Roseni Moreira Teixeira, Oct 24, 2023, on the Plataforma Integrada de Ovidoria e Acesso à Informação

⁶ All translations are mine.

In spite of this documented fact, GKP gives arguments that DLE was within the law when present in indigenous areas during the period in question. One of these arguments is DLE's status as a missionary of SIL.

Eventually FUNAI reached an understanding with SIL that allowed all of its members to continue working in indigenous villages, not as missionaries but in order to do linguistic research and translate morally uplifting works into indigenous languages. That blanket permission for SIL members covered Everett after he completed the PhD at UNICAMP, until 2001. During that period he never needed to fill out the permit application forms used by university academics, whether Brazilian or foreign, which is why (as suspicious Brazilian researchers have found) searches in the public record for his applications via that channel come up with no results. (Pullum 2024b: 39)

It is, of course, false that "searches in the public record for his applications via that channel come up with no results": records are sitting in the files of the AAEP in FUNAI, as shown above, available to SIC inquiries.

It is not clear how and when the claimed "blanket permission for SIL members" was granted; there is no reference given for this. Even if he could be legally present and conduct research among the Pirahã as a SIL missionary in a period ending in 2001 (he sometimes denied that he was a missionary during that time), missionary status for that period would not entitle him to host unauthorized researchers in the Pirahã area, nor to be there after 2001, nor to enter other indigenous areas.

While missionaries, in principle, are present in indigenous areas for good works (it is illegal in Brazil to interfere with indigenous religion), the reality is quite different. DLE's ex-wife Keren Everett provided an account of the Everetts' activities among the Pirahã on a Christian website,⁷ commenting that the Pirahã welcomed them back, but "Still the spiritual warfare has been really strong. Every time the Pirahã saw a filmstrip about Jesus and his resurrection, the spirits would fight back. The Pirahã are still just as primitive and isolated as when they were contacted; the spirits have such a strong hold on them." DLE was apparently also engaged in this combat against Pirahã beliefs at this time, though he has claimed to have become an atheist and to begin to consider missionary work as colonialist about fifteen years earlier, when he went to MIT (see below).

In a report written as an anthropological consultant, Walter Coutinho Jr and his assistant, Fabíola Emanuelle Silva Vilar,⁸ observe that

Ainda à revista *Veja*, Everett relata que, em 1984, quando foi trabalhar no MIT, já se transformara em um ateu e por isso sua atuação na T.I. passou a assumir um caráter científico, conforme suas próprias palavras: "Nesse tempo, meus serviços como missionário se tomaram uma fachada para o que realmente me interessava, que eram os estudos de linguística". Estas declarações sugerem que Everett usava sua posição de missionário e de linguista de acordo com a sua conveniência, não atuando com transparência.

⁷ <https://web.archive.org/web/20090705163948/http://www.canadianchristianity.com/cgi-bin/bc.cgi?bc/bccn/0101/supgod> (03/08/2026)

⁸ INFORMAÇÃO No 05/2014-CÍVEL5/PR/AM, September 22, 2014, from DLE's MPF (Federal Public Ministry) dossier (Inquérito Civil 1.31.000.000601/2007- 75)

[In an interview with Veja magazine, Everett recounts that, in 1984, when he went to work at MIT, he had already become an atheist and therefore his work in the indigenous reserve took on a scientific character, in his own words: "At that time, my services as a missionary became a front for what really interested me, which was the study of linguistics." These statements suggest that Everett used his position as a missionary and linguist for his own convenience, not acting transparently.]

It is worth observing that most members of the Brazilian scientific community consider such efforts to abolish native beliefs as ethically repugnant, whether carried out by a true Christian, an atheist, or someone presenting himself as both. And it is members of the Brazilian scientific community who judge project proposals for the CNPq. To see the opinion of Amazonianist linguists and anthropologists about SIL, consult their open letter to UNESCO⁹ pointing out that UNESCO's stated goal of maintaining cultural diversity is incompatible with having SIL as a consultant for the agency. This letter is a valuable document for the history of Amazonian linguistics since it presents a quick but accurate view of SIL's key place in the network of fundamentalist missionary organizations in Brazil and shows their methods and goals. It also contains the only existing summary of where Latin American linguistic students were conducting doctoral studies on Amazonian languages in 2023, both in Latin American centers and those abroad.

GKP presents two other arguments that DLE was in the villages legally. The first of the two, for which he has no basis, has to do with the supposed adequacy of regional authorization.

There are different ways for permanent residents to work: they can apply to the national office of FUNAI, or go through a local FUNAI office in the appropriate region provided Brasília does not object. They can also visit at the request of an indigenous group, which FUNAI is required to accept. (Pullum 2024b: 39)

This is disinformation and a false account of research authorizations, designed to excuse DLE's lack of a real research authorization, which comes in written form. No one has seen such a document with DLE's name on it in the last thirty years. GKP, following DLE, promotes the fiction that a researcher can circumvent the requirements of a formal authorization request if he can obtain a local authorization from a regional authority. In fact, local authorizations are only temporary for minor matters or practical assistance measures. If DLE was doing the groundbreaking, earth-shaking research that he claims, he definitely needed a research authorization to enter Pirahã territory, especially if accompanied by foreign researchers or students. A practical disproof of GKP's fiction is DLE's expulsion as a result of the investigatory visit of the FUNAI and police to the Pirahã in January of 2007 (see below). DLE had inveigled a local permission from a FUNAI worker in the FUNAI office in Porto Velho. Since this was not what was required, he and his four students were discovered and expelled, and he became mired in the resulting scandal. It is unfortunate that GKP spreads this fiction about research authorization. If a young researcher believed this and acted on it, he could end up in trouble, like DLE.

Another argument presented by GKP is that no one bothered about DLE being there for some time.

⁹ <http://etnolinguistica.wdfiles.com/local--files/biblio%3Aletter-unesco-2022/Letter%20to%20Unesco%20about%20SIL-1.pdf> (03/08/2026)

One way or another, Everett has always had the needed permits, and two national-level directors of FUNAI (including the much-respected Apoena Meirelles) visited Everett while he lived with the Pirahã, which would hardly have happened if he was an illegal foreign interloper. (Pullum 2024b: 39)

In fact, Meirelles is regarded today by the progressive FUNAI staff as a *sertanista* (FUNAI field worker) of an older generation who was more interested in favorable publicity than in keeping the indigenous groups that he contacted alive (for which Meirelles had a bad record). He was certainly unconcerned about the legitimacy of his associates, though I will not go into examples here.

5. The evolution of DLE's problems with the FUNAI

When DLE was just a missionary in a remote location, no attention was given to his case. However, that changed in 2004 and 2005 when workers of the Coordination of Studies and Research (AAEP) noticed that he had high-profile international research projects with indigenous groups which were being displayed on the Internet. I used to visit the AAEP from time to time to take care of my own authorization and those of visiting researchers at my institution, the Museu Goeldi in Belém, Pará, as well as to deliver reports and copies of works and discuss possible cooperative measures for the native peoples with the AAEP staff. That is normal and good administrative practice.

In a visit to the AAEP on October 10, 2004 (recorded in one of my notebooks), during a discussion of linguistic research in Brazil, some staff member mentioned that they had become aware, via the Internet, that there were three large international projects involving DLE and a total of five languages: Suyá, Pirahã, Sateré-Mawé, Banawa and Yarawara. They were wondering about authorization for these. In another visit on June 3, 2005, the coordinators of the AAEP, Cláudio Romero and Marco Antônio E. Santos, told me that DLE had taken some Suyá to the UK and Europe. While the Brazilian members of the Suyá project were authorized to enter the indigenous reserve, DLE was not. While he could still conduct research outside the reserve, that was a dubious way to conduct a field research project, which, in fact, did not work out well. One worker said that the AAEP was sending e-mails to the funding agencies who were financing the three international projects, asking them to not support illegal activities in Brazil and requesting them to have the principal investigator of the projects send copies to the AAEP to begin their regularization.

The main result of this is that DLE's lack of authorization appeared on the AAEP's radar. This, of course, had nothing to do with Noam Chomsky or affiliated linguists. Apparently, there was no answer to the requests to regularize the projects. When I visited the AAEP again on March 8, 2006, Cláudio Romero appeared very frustrated with DLE and said, rather grimly, "He is going to get you all in trouble." That is, xenophobic tendencies, which exist everywhere, could take advantage of this example to seek to curtail foreign researchers. This possibility is worse if foreigners appear to be covering for each other.

With the appearance of DLE's *Current Anthropology* article in 2005 and subsequent publicity, attention turned to the Pirahã and the same story of lack of authorization.

Cilene Rodrigues,¹⁰ who was living in Brasília in 2006, went to central FUNAI to see if there were any Pirahã speakers there, to check some facts about the language. There she was referred to Cláudio Romero. It was natural for Cláudio Romero, doing his job, to ask Rodrigues and her coauthor and collaborator, Andrew Nevins, as linguists who spoke English and knew what was happening internationally, for information about the elusive DLE. They responded in the form of a letter in December of 2006, to which GKP refers. I obtained a copy of the letter¹¹ from the FUNAI. It starts with an observation that DLE seemed to have no affiliation with a Brazilian institution, suggesting doubt about his authorization status. Then they continue with background facts about DLE's past as a missionary and later as an academic. They then give their quite severe opinion that DLE's portrait of the Pirahã was negative and disrespectful and in conflict with the findings of the anthropologist Marco Antônio Gonçalves. They cite some quotes as examples. One of these is from a letter by one Dennis Cone, editor of CTT – Current Thoughts and Trends, a Christian website, apparently based on information from the Everetts: "They [the Pirahã] frequently sing to the evil spirits all night long, opening themselves up to demon possession. Whenever the missionaries showed a filmstrip about Jesus, the evil spirits would fight back."¹² Another quote, from DLE, on a webpage,¹³ was

They find food and eat when they are hungry, they sleep when they are tired. Marriage, like their houses and other belongings, is not meant to be permanent. They live life a day at a time and do not look to the future. Their village is alive twenty-four hours a day with constant chatter and movement. The local traders say they "talk like chickens and act like monkeys." They are pleasure seekers fond of bead necklaces, sugar cane, and whiskey.

The two authors include a quote from DLE's talk¹⁴ at MIT in 2006: "I always buy my friendship with candy and tobacco." (To be fair, in the recording of the talk this appears to be jocular.)

At no point did the letter bring up considerations of linguistic theory. Nor does it contain any request for a "ban" on DLE's authorization. The word 'racism' never appears. Toward the end of the letter, the two young authors state their concerns. Two of these were rather naïve: the supply of tobacco and sugar to the Pirahã and the whereabouts of a child who supposedly had learned to count and then disappeared, having been sent far away. The third concern would touch on what was already a sore spot for the AAEP: DLE's lack of authorization. In his talk at MIT in 2006, DLE had said that Tecumseh Fitch had gone with him to the Pirahã in 2006 and that Ted Gibson and Mike Frank would do so in 2007, with no indication that any of this was authorized. The authors of the letter were only repeating public information from DLE himself.

In fact, the authors were understating authorization questions by far. In his talk at MIT in December of 2006, DLE gave, rather proudly, a long list of researchers that he had taken to the Pirahã. Aside from seven Brazilian graduate students and one Brazilian linguist, the list included a number of foreign researchers, which is a more sensitive issue: three USA graduate

¹⁰ E-mail, Rodrigues to Moore, September 23, 2023

¹¹ Letter to Cláudio Romero, CGEP, from Cilene Rodrigues and Andrew Nevins, 16 December 2006, Citizen Information Request protocol 08198.052501/2023-18, answered on 19 December 2023

¹² <http://www.navpress.com/EPubs/DisplayArticle/3/3.26.81.html> (obsolete)

¹³ <http://web.archive.org/web/20001121191700/amazonling.linguist.pitt.edu/people.html> (obsolete)

¹⁴ https://web.archive.org/web/20100708044816/http://tedlab.mit.edu/tedlab_website/news/everett-recording-2006.wma (03/08/2026)

students, three UK graduate students, one Dutch graduate student, one German student, and the researchers Peter Gordon (1989, 1990 and 1991), Peter Ladefoged, Leo Wetzels and Jeanette Sakel. We know that the four foreign students who were with DLE when they were all expelled in 2007 were not authorized, and there is no indication that any others on the list were authorized. DLE had no authorization after 2001, but said in the talk that he goes back to the Pirahã every year. So he had been conducting a veritable GTDAR caravan of unauthorized researchers for many years, both as a missionary and as an academic. Probably the AAEP already knew about at least some of these.

The conclusion of the letter by Rodrigues and Nevins was only that FUNAI should check on the authorization of DLE: “On the basis of the questions cited above, we ask that FUNAI, by means of your mediation, investigate the research procedures of Daniel Everett among the Pirahã and verify his credentials and authorization for entry in the indigenous territory in question.”

GKP presents this letter as causing DLE’s problems with FUNAI and presents his account of its contents--though he never read it.

In 2007, Everett received an unexpected phone call from the distinguished journalist Larry Rohter, who had been South American bureau chief for The New York Times since 1999. Rohter was in the office of the director (presidente) of FUNAI (Fundação Nacional do Índio, later renamed Fundação Nacional dos Povos Indígenas), the Brazilian government agency charged with overseeing the welfare and protection of the country’s indigenous people. He had in his hands a letter written to FUNAI by Cilene Rodrigues. Rohter read the Portuguese text to Everett over the phone.

The letter expressed objections to Everett’s linguistic research and his representation of Pirahã culture. It may also have expressed the view that he was not a suitable person to be permitted to work with Brazilian Indians. I have not seen the letter... (Pullum 2024a: 5)

In fact, the information and request in the letter arrived at a time when Cláudio Romero was already frustrated with DLE. The FUNAI’s subsequent actions involving DLE were because of his stubbornly illegal GTDAR behavior, not because the authors of the letter requested them, something for which they would have had no authority in any case. Opinions have little weight; everyone has one. Illegality is another matter. The letter was only one indication, among several, of DLE’s irregular status, already well known to the AAEP.

GKP repeats DLE’s account of the time when he was confronted by FUNAI and their police escort in a Pirahã village.

There was an occasion in 2007 when Everett was with the Pirahã along with several students and a local FUNAI official with a grudge against him reported that they were there illegally. A heavily armed team of military police made the long river journey through a rainstorm to get to the relevant Pirahã village and arrest him. Everett greeted them in fluent Portuguese, showed them his permanent residence document and his letter from the local FUNAI office. The policemen relaxed, and posed smiling for a photo with members of Everett’s team. A few days later in Porto Velho, he was called in by the FUNAI office there over the same incident, and again satisfied the organization that he had done everything legally. (Pullum 2024a: 9)

However, the real facts are in the report from the FUNAI and police expedition below. It shows that the account given by GKP and DLE is false. While GKP says that this expedition to investigate DLE was triggered by “a local FUNAI agent who had a grudge against him,” DLE himself, on his facebook page, May 23, 2019, claims that “a JOCUM/YWAM missionary who had always been asking me for money because he was sure I was rich (and he STILL asks) reported me to the local FUNAI office in Humaitá.”

In any case, whether by the instigation of a local FUNAI official or a JOCUM missionary, FUNAI workers and some police went to investigate DLE on 16-17 January 2007. GKP offers the quaint account of the encounter quoted above, narrated in dramatic fashion, as though he had been present. In his version, there is a happy ending and DLE and students are found to have everything in order.

The report of the episode, however, tells a starkly different story, in which DLE offered the police only a local authorization, which was inadequate. Four foreign students (Edward Gibson, Michael Franck, Jeanette Sakel and Eugenie Stapert) were then found there, without research authorizations. They were all sent away from the indigenous reserve, along with the Everetts. The Travel Report of the expedition states:¹⁵

Aproximadamente às 07:00h quando nos preparávamos para fazer a abordagem, para comprirmos, conforme a designação da nossa ordem de serviço, que solicitava averiguar “in loco” a entrada de pessoas não autorizadas a adentrarem na Terra Indígena Pirahã, compareceu no posto de saúde da Aldeia Forquilha Grande onde estávamos, o Sr. Daniel Everett, que nos apresentou uma Declaração autorizando a permanência dos mesmos no período de 12/01/07 a 19/01/07, assinada pelo Administrador Substituto, Sr. Osman Ribeiro Brasil, em 10/01/07 em anexo cópia da mesma, o que fora realmente constatado por nossa equipe e pelo Cmte da Polícia Ambiental de Humaitá—AM, soldado PM Aparecido Moreira Leal e o Cmte dos militares para essa missão, Cabo PM Manoel de Souza Limeira.

Após a apresentação do documento, nos dirigimos até a casa onde constatamos que havia mais pessoas, e perguntando ao Sr. Daniel Everett quem são, ele nos informou que eram alunos seus, e que estudam a sintaxe e a fonologia dos Pirahãs, em anexo relação nominal dos estudantes que se encontram na casa datada de 17/01/07 e assinada pelo Sr. Daniel Everett, o Sr. Daniel Everett informou-nos que parte do grupo dos alunos retornariam já na tarde do dia 17/01/07 e o restante no dia 18/01/07, pois o avião que os levaria era pequeno e não comportaria todos num só voo.

[At approximately 7:00 A.M., as we were preparing to approach, to comply with the designation of our service order, which requested that we verify “in loco” the entry of unauthorized persons into the Pirahã Indigenous Land, Mr. Daniel Everett appeared at the health post in the Forquilha Grande Village where we were, and presented us with a Declaration authorizing their stay from 01/12/07 to 01/19/07, signed by the Substitute Administrator, Mr. Osman Ribeiro Brasil, on 01/10/07, with a copy attached, which was actually confirmed by our team and by the Commander of the Environmental Police of

¹⁵ Relatório de Viagens (Travel Report) by Laércio Henriques Baraúna, document obtained from the MPF dossiê about DLE, (Inquérito Civil 1.31.000.000601/2007- 75)

Humaitá—AM, soldier PM Aparecido Moreira Leal and the Commander of the military personnel for this mission, Corporal PM Manoel de Souza Limeira.”

After presenting the document, we went to the house where we found that there were more people, and asking Mr. Daniel Everett who they were, he informed us that they were his students, and that they study the syntax and phonology of the Pirahãs, attached is a nominal list of the students who are in the house dated 17/01/07 and signed by Mr. Daniel Everett, Mr. Daniel Everett informed us that part of the group of students would return in the afternoon of 17/01/07 and the rest on 18/01/07, as the plane that would take them was small and would not accommodate them all in a single flight.]

There were several ramifications of this episode. One is that the unfortunate author of the local permission, Osman Brasil, was called upon to explain his actions. He replied that he had been misled by DLE. His account of the matter states,¹⁶

Que após um afastamento de 05 anos, o Dr. DANIEL compareceu a este Núcleo (Então Administração Executiva Regional da FUNAI, solicitando Autorização ingressar na Terra Indígena, segundo sua alegação, apenas para rever os amigos e por em dia alguns detalhes de sua pesquisa. Que em nenhum momento citou que seria acompanhado pelos seus alunos, também estrangeiros. Que em confiança, e por sempre vê-lo em contato com os Indígenas e por não saber de qualquer reclamação sobre sua conduta, expedimos a declaração, mesmo assim, enfatizando IPSIS LITERIS “...com a finalidade proceder visita aos Índios e dar prosseguimento aos trabalhos de pesquisas linguísticas...”. Que em momento algum foi ventilada a intenção de trazer alunos, fazer documentários ou uso de imagem. Que tão logo recebemos a denúncia de que Daniel Everett estaria junto com seus alunos, procedendo estudos, pesquisas e uso de imagem dos Mura Pirahã, expedimos a Ordem de Serviço nº 009/STP/ERA/PVH de 16 de Janeiro de 2007, autorizando o deslocamento dos Servidores LAÉRCIO HENRIQUES BARAÚNA e JOSUÉ TAVARES DA SILVA, para averiguarem a entrada de estrangeiros na Terra Indígena Mura Pirahã.

[That after a five-year absence, Dr. DANIEL appeared at this Center (then the Regional Executive Administration of FUNAI), requesting Authorization to enter the Indigenous Land, according to his claim, only to see his friends and update some details of his research. That at no time did he mention that he would be accompanied by his students, also foreigners. That in trust, and because we always see him in contact with the Indigenous people and because we were not aware of any complaints about his conduct, we issued the statement, nevertheless, emphasizing IPSIS LITERIS “...for the purpose of visiting the Indigenous people and continuing the work of linguistic research...”. That at no time was there any mention of the intention of bringing students, making documentaries, or using their images. That as soon as we received the complaint that Daniel Everett was with his students, conducting studies, research, and using images of the Mura Pirahã, we issued Service Order No. 009/STP/ERA/PVH of January 16, 2007, authorizing the movement of Civil Servants LAÉRCIO HENRIQUES BARAÚNA

¹⁶ Ofício no. 132/GAB/NÃO/FUNAI, Osman Ribeiro Brasil para Andreia Pistono Vitalino, MPF, June 20, 2008, documento of the MPF dossier (Inquérito Civil 1.31.000.000601/2007- 75)

and JOSUÉ TAVARES DA SILVA, to investigate the entry of foreigners into the Mura Pirahã Indigenous Land.].

This document from Osman Brasil, along with the SIC-FUNAI response to my inquiry about DLE's authorization record (Section 4) and the Travel Report of the expulsion of DLE and his four students from Pirahã territory in 2007, accompanied by the English translation of these documents, was presented in a discussion of the matter on the Facebook page of Marc van Oostendorp in January, 2024. These contradict GKP's story that DLE was found to be blameless by the police. GKP mentions these documents on Facebook, presumably viewed them and knew they were inconsistent with his account.

Another effect of the expulsion was that the Ministério Público Federal, alarmed, ordered that the FUNAI workers in the regional centers in Porto Velho, Guajará-Mirim, Cacoal and Ji-Paraná read and sign a copy of the rules governing research access to indigenous areas. There were more than 100 signatures in compliance. This created an atmosphere of suspicion that honest researchers had to deal with.

The episode had sufficient notoriety that numerous communications between the MPF and FUNAI about it were passed back and forth, on and on, for years. Even five years later, on June 22, 2012, the MPF of Amazonas requested information about whether DLE and his students were authorized and what measures were taken in their case. The response by the head of the regional FUNAI office, Valmir Parintintin (who appears in Everett's film, section 7.3 below), begins as follows:¹⁷

A autorização para pesquisa junto a qualquer povo indígena é feita somente pela Presidência da FUNAI, após consulta à respectiva Coordenação Regional e anuência do povo indígena em questão. Não há, por parte desta CR e da Presidência, nenhuma autorização para qualquer pesquisador desenvolver pesquisas na Terra Indígena Pirahã. Os pesquisadores liderados por Daniel Everett e Karen Everett foram retirados da área através de ação da FUNAI/NAL-HUMAITÁ, com apoio da Polícia Federal em 2007.

[Authorization for research with any indigenous group is only given by the Presidency of FUNAI, after consultation with the respective Regional Coordination and agreement by the indigenous people in question. There is in this Regional Coordination, no authorization for any researcher to conduct research on the Indigenous Territory of the Pirahã. The researchers led by Daniel Everett and Karen Everett were removed from the area by the action of FUNAI/NAL-HUMAITÁ, with support from the Federal Police in 2007.]

Note that this states clearly that the only way to get authorization for extensive research is through central FUNAI in Brasília, not by any regional office.

One salutary effect of the expulsion was that, after that experience, DLE desisted from GTDAR and was part of a legitimate application for research among the Pirahã, file number 0594/07, signed on 27 January 2008, submitted to the AEX-CNPq. The Brazilian head of the research team was Aryon Rodrigues and the head of the foreign team was Ulrich Sauerland. The

¹⁷ Ofício no. 149/GAB/FUNAI/CR-MADEIRA/2012) from Valmir Parintintin to Dr. Eloi Francisco Zatti Faccioni, MPF – Amazonas, 05/07/2012, document contained in MPF dossier (Inquérito Civil 1.31.000.000601/2007- 75)

proposal was ambitious, with eleven researchers, including DLE, and a time span of 30 March 2008 to 31 December 2011.¹⁸

According to Sauerland,¹⁹ the head of the AAEP, Cláudio Romero, stood up to Aryon Rodrigues and refused to authorize the project if DLE was included. So Sauerland agreed to eliminate DLE from the team and the project was authorized (authorization number 163/CGEP/08), though for a shorter period, 15 November 2008 to 31 May 2009, and its activities were greatly reduced in practice. Note that this was not a “ban” on DLE, rather a bad record that was taken into account when he made a request to FUNAI. That is how the rules are enforced: either respect the rules or don’t come back.

Sauerland’s account is confirmed by a later official letter from the Acting President of the FUNAI, Maria Augusta Boulitreau, to the MPF. She states²⁰

Para Daniel Everett há dois pedidos de permissão para entrar na TI Pirahã: o primeiro datado de 2007, junto a outros pesquisadores, para desenvolver o projeto “A Língua Pirahã: Dicionário, Contato Linguístico e Recursividade”. Inicialmente o pedido fora negado, uma vez que havia denúncias contra o pesquisador (tanto na TI Pirahã quanto em situação anterior, junto aos Suyá – a denúncia encontra-se às folhas 09 e 11 do processo). A autorização (folha 158) só foi concedida à equipe, para o período entre 15/11/2008 a 31/05/2009, após o coordenador do projeto afirmar que Daniel Everett não faria parte da equipe que iria a campo.

[For Daniel Everett there are two requests for permission to enter the TI Pirahã: the first dated 2007, together with other researchers, to carry out the project ‘The Pirahã Language: Dictionary, Linguistic Contact and Recursivity’. Initially the request was denied, since there were complaints about the researcher (both in the TI Pirahã and in the earlier situation, among the Suyá—the complaints are found in pages 09 and 11 of the file). The authorization (page 158) was given to the team, for the period between 15/11/2008 and 31/05/2009, after the coordinator of the project affirmed that Daniel Everett would not be part of the team which would enter the field.]

GKP’s account omits all of this. He may not be aware of it, given his reliance on DLE as a source of information. Instead, he presents a fiction that DLE’s difficulties with FUNAI as some unreasonable ban that FUNAI would not discuss: (Pullum 2024a: 5)

He was later able to get permission from the local FUNAI office to visit the area merely as an aide and interpreter to a film team during the making of the 2012 documentary film *The Grammar of Happiness*, but his applications to do grant-supported field research on the language met with negative decisions.

Everett flew to Brasília to discuss the situation, accompanied by the doyen of Amazonian research, the late Aryon Rodrigues (1925–2014), who had been a mentor to him during his doctoral studies. They had set up a meeting with the national director of

¹⁸ Document obtained from FUNAI by Citizen Information Request protocol 08198.052501/2023-18, answered on 19 December 2023

¹⁹ E-mail Sauerland to Moore, 25 January 2024

²⁰ Ofício no. 547/2014/PRES-FUNAI-MJ, July 16, 2014

FUNAI, Márcio Meira, but Meira did not show up. Instead he sent a deputy [who] had no power to make executive decisions. (Pullum 2024a: 5)

In fact, his journalistic authorization (apparently emitted by a different department of FUNAI, not the AAEP) was given by central FUNAI in 2009, not by a local office. The trip to Brasília, assuming that this was the trip portrayed in his film, was in 2011, four years after he was expelled from the Pirahã and three years after he was excluded from the authorization request of 2008. Márcio Meira²¹ vaguely recalls hearing about DLE, whom he recalled as seeming to have a sketchy reputation. But Meira, as president of a large governmental organization, said that he never personally received researchers, who were instead directed to the appropriate department, which would have been the AAEP (with Cláudio Romero). There would be no justification for DLE to request special treatment instead of following normal channels.

We can summarize the DLE-FUNAI saga in Brazil as the case of a linguist who operated on a GTDAR basis outside of Brazilian law for years, contrary to the ethical codes of all the relevant professional organizations (ABRALIN, ABA, LSA, AAA), finally getting caught and ending up in trouble and experiencing difficulty in access to the field because of this. DLE, always resourceful, took these lemons and made lemonade. Knowing that very few people would have the motivation or ability to check the facts in Brazil, he claimed to have been a victim of persecution.

In this story, the Persecution Hoax, the brilliant DLE was such a grave threat to Chomsky's hegemonic theories that Chomsky's henchmen, through slander and underhanded means, had the blameless true scientist DLE banned from field research, so that he could not continue his ground-breaking earth-shaking studies. Some nasty, envious linguists in Brazil abetted this persecution. It is worthy of a study in Social Psychology to trace how this hoax has achieved mythic characteristics and become widespread. Some of its manifestations are discussed in section 7 below.

6. Some opinions cited by GKP

A number of linguists and journalists in the USA and Europe, with no access to crucial facts in Brazil, especially those with anti-Chomsky sentiments, were easily convinced of this hoax, which GKP repeats frequently. Specialists in Amazonian languages are much better informed and give the hoax little credence. The events were more than fifteen years ago and Amazonian linguists have more important priorities.

GKP cites some opinions of others in support of his views. These need to be weighed critically. He claims that the treatment of DLE by Nevins, Pesetsky and Rodrigues soured the discussion of Pirahã, leading to disrepute in the field, as expressed by the Amazonianist Alexandra Aikhenvald: (Pullum 2024b: 43):

The work NP&R have done to damage Everett's reputation has been ample to color the general impression a newcomer to the dispute will pick up. The superbly detailed survey of Amazonian languages by Aikhenvald (2012) takes the line of treating the issues as unfit for discussion, declaring that "there is neither consistency nor plausibility to the quasi-analytical statements which have been made concerning this language [Pirahã], or its culture, during the past fifteen years. I refrain from quoting

²¹ personal communication, May 9, 2024

these sources.” (p. 411, n. 91). She thus avoids any discussion of the polemics of the post-2005 literature. In fact she cites nothing on Pirahã dated later than 1986.

However, if one reads Aikhenvald’s original sentence, one sees that GKP disingenuously deleted the first part of the sentence to give the false impression that the object of her disdain is the polemics of the post-2005 literature. In fact, the whole sentence, restored, shows that her disdain is for the SIL statements on Pirahã in the last fifteen years, which would be mainly those of DLE: “Three teams of missionaries from SIL have worked on Pirahã, but there is neither consistency nor plausibility to the quasi-analytical statements which have been made concerning the language, or its culture, during the past fifteen years. I refrain from quoting those dubious sources.”

Similarly, in their book on Amazonian languages, Dixon and Aikhenvald (1999: 353) express doubts about the research on Pirahã, which was done by SIL, notably by DLE: “The Mura tribes had a tumultuous history, and speak an unusual language. Unfortunately, there are many points of uncertainty concerning both.”

It is pertinent to observe that the study of Amazonian languages has progressed greatly in this century. At a recent conference of the Amazonicas series,²² in Belém, Brazil, August 11-16, 2025, there were something on the order of 150-200 participating linguists, from all over the world. Apparently, none of them were missionaries. No papers about DLE’s research were presented. It is also noteworthy that Latin American participation in DLE’s 2024 festschrift was zero.

Another opinion which GKP (Pullum 2024b: 68) presents is an accolade from a young Brazilian anthropologist, Pedro Vaz Felizes:

Future historians of our field will have to decide whether the campaign of innuendo, insult, libel, and bureaucratic warfare against Everett was an edifying or justifiable way to pursue linguistic science. They might do well to pay attention to a remark made by a young Brazilian anthropologist who has been working with the Pirahã people in recent years, as recently expressed in his Master’s thesis (Felizes 2023: 59)

A relação de Daniel e Karen Everett com os Pirahã é algo que perdura até aos dias atuais. Durante mais de quarenta anos de convívio - permanente ou esporádico - conquistaram a reputação de grandes amigos, de saberem bem a língua, de serem exímios contadores de histórias e de se tornarem importantes aliados, a quem os Pirahã geralmente recorrem para resolver potenciais conflitos ou aprender coisas sobre o mundo dos brancos.

[Daniel and Keren Everett’s relationship with the Pirahã is something that has endured to the present day. During more than forty years of coexistence – permanent or sporadic—they gained the reputation of being great friends, of knowing the language well, of being excellent storytellers and of becoming important allies, to whom the Pirahã often turn to resolve potential conflicts or learn things about the white world.]

²² <https://gelcia.com.br/eventos/amazonicas10/> (03/08/2026)

This young anthropologist seems to be a serious person, with the soul of an artist. Reading his dissertation, we see that he received help from Keren Madora (ex-Everett) for information and transcription, creating a certain dependency and debt. He says²³ that she seems to have left the SIL and JOCUM missions and continues in contact with the Pirahã, doing some good works. That does not necessarily imply that she has abandoned combatting satanic native beliefs. Why he generalizes to include DLE, who has not been there for fifteen years, is not clear. Perhaps diplomacy. His detailed account of Pirahã cosmology (Felizes 2023: 163-207), in comparative perspective, agrees with the description given by the anthropologist Marco Antônio Gonçalves, mentioned by Chernela (2022) in section 7.1 below, not with DLE's claims about the same matters. Felizes does not concern himself with those.

7. Other versions of the myth—the Persecution Hoax

When facts are scarce, myths abound. This has been striking in the case of DLE in Brazil. Myths have variants (as Lévi-Strauss noted) and this has been true of the Persecution Hoax, which has a number of variations, scattered about, often mutually inconsistent with each other and with the documented historical record.

7.1 The *Annual Review of Anthropology*: phantom petition but professional anthropological findings

Even the anthropologist Janet Chernela, who has experience in Brazil, states, with no evidence, that “In Brazil, linguists and anthropologists petitioned the government to bar Everett from entering Pirahã territory, and, in 2011, they succeeded” (Chernela 2023: 138). This is baseless; no one in Brazil knows of any such petition. Apparently, she did not know of the expulsion of DLE and his students in 2007 nor his troubles with FUNAI, but absorbed notions about some letter and a supposed “ban” and created this variant as something that seemed reasonable.

In his review of Chernela's article, GKP (2024b: 43-45) criticizes her linguistic discussion but does not mention her presentation of inconvenient finding by a professional anthropologist with extensive research among the Pirahã. She cites DLE's claim that Pirahã “has no creation myths—its texts are almost always descriptions of immediate experience or interpretation of experience; it has some stories about the past, but only of one or two generations back.” (Everett 2005: 622) About his claims Chernela 2023: 144) says,

Like other examples of so-called gaps that Everett notes, this claim is not supported by evidence. The anthropologist Gonçalves (1988, 1993, 2001 [424 pages]) provides ample evidence of myth and abstract thought. In three major collections of cosmologies, he describes a robust body of religious and symbolic conceptualization of the world, its origin, cosmic laws and principles and numerous other intangible phenomena that entail complex reasoning and discursive processes.

These findings undermine the credibility of DLE's 2005 claims, which include much more than just syntax.

7.2 Tom Wolfe's comic-book-flavored version of the Persecution Hoax

²³ E-mail Felizes to Moore, March 30, 2024

Another variant of the Persecution Hoax is found in Tom Wolfe's 2016 book, *The Kingdom of Speech*. This presents his version of a DLE vs. Chomsky saga. It disproves anyone who thought that linguistics is a field that is too dry to be sensationalized. Wolfe's treatment is glib, superficial and highly entertaining. Apparently, much of the information on which the account is based is from DLE. Who else would know that DLE's father took him to a Mexican whorehouse at the age of 14 and banged on the door when he took too long inside (Wolfe 2016: 110)? Information from Brazil seems limited to a mention of Chomsky's calling DLE a "charlatan" in a Brazilian newspaper (Wolfe 2016: 143). Wolfe makes embarrassingly foolish claims, for example that "The Pirahã had not only the simplest language on earth but also the simplest culture" (Wolfe: 116). Like GKP, Wolfe recounts supposed episodes in Brazil as though he had been present. Some of his characterizations of the Pirahã are unflattering, for example, his account (p. 139) of drunken Pirahã wanting to attack DLE:

Everett, exhausted, a nervous wreck, goes into the storeroom with everybody else, collapses asleep-- *--thump crash arrggggh more thuds groans agonized grunts...* on all sides of the storeroom only *one inch away*—that being the thickness of the storeroom wall right behind them, right before them, on both sides of them—*one inch away*—when *splat hock jaaaggh thump yaaak groan eeeowww* the whole storeroom shakes, shudders, trampolines on the platform...the bastards could break into this little room *just like that* if they knew we were in here, but for now they're bent only on beating each other senseless *thump crack groan ooof ummmph*. (Italics in the original)

They seem like nasty brutes in this account, but Wolfe (p. 129) assures us that "Everett expressed nothing but admiration for the Pirahã."

Of course, Wolfe does not mention DLE's GTDAR record, nor his expulsion, with his wife and four foreign students, from the Pirahã reserve in 2007, nor his exclusion from the project of Aryan Rodrigues and Ulrich Sauerland in 2008, which resulted from the scandal of his expulsion and past behavior. Instead, Wolfe (p. 129) repeats a version of DLE's conspiracy theory, this time with a notification said to be conveyed to DLE via an enigmatic "canary with a PhD" (who left no written trace):

In Everett's case, putting an end to his life's work was a clandestine operation. Not long after Colapintos's New Yorker article appeared, Everett was in the United States teaching at Illinois State University when he got a call from a canary with a PhD informing him that a Brazilian government agency known as FUNAI, the Portuguese acronym for the National Indian Foundation, was denying him permission to return to the Pirahã...on the grounds that what he had written about them was...racist. He was dumbfounded.

However, as was explained above, DLE's difficulties with FUNAI stemmed from his own GTDAR behavior, not from persecution.

7.3 The pseudodocumentary version of the Persecution Hoax: the film *The Grammar of Happiness*, also called *The Amazon Code*

Yet another version of events is portrayed in Everett's 2012 film, which is a pseudo-documentary consisting of a lovely Amazonian travelogue, an account of DLE's claimed evolution into atheism, recursion hype and the Persecution Hoax. In this version, which is incompatible

with both Wolfe's version and the written documents, DLE's difficulties occur in 2011, about four years after the canary with a PhD was said by Wolfe to have announced the claimed "ban" on Everett's entry into the indigenous area. (One should not expect different versions of a myth to have the same chronology.)

The film was produced by Essential Media and Entertainment in association with Sertão Filmes for Smithsonian Networks. The Producer/Co-Director/Co-Writer is Michael O'Neill. Two Brazilians were intimately involved in the filming: Pedro Novaes, Co-Producer and head of Sertão Filmes, and Pedro Saldanha, Sound Recordist.²⁴ It is available on the Internet. A version on YouTube (52:01) will be used as a reference.²⁵ The location of scenes in minutes refer to this version. A version in Portuguese is *A Língua Pirahã – o Código do Amazonas*.²⁶

Because of the divergence of the film from the reality known from professional experience and documents and because many of the scenes were obviously staged, I consulted with Novaes e Saldanha about the procedures and content of making the film.²⁷

The first half of the film has a number of scenes of the Amazon forest and rivers (along with some light, inspirational music), capturing their magnificence and beauty, as well as many scenes with the Pirahã. This footage was collected in the first trip of the filmmakers to the Pirahã. Everett's presence on that trip was authorized by the FUNAI for the period 20 June – 30 August 2009. Someone in the Communications sector of FUNAI once told me that they authorized this film project, thinking it would be interesting. They were unaware of DLE's problems with the AAEP.

The Pirahã appear in the film as graceful and good-humored, not like the loose-living bunch described in the quote from DLE in Cilene Rodrigues' letter to the AAEP, nor like the nasty brutes in Wolfe's book. In the film, there is no hint of the problems facing the Pirahã, which are described in the two Funai reports cited in 1.0 above. Instead, complacency is the norm as the Pirahã are presented as living in Happyland owing to their limit on only thinking about the present. The film's narrator, in a smooth, slightly sultry voice, observes (minute 19:12), "As Everett immersed himself in their world, he had a profound realization: the Pirahã appear to live entirely in the present." She observes (19:40) that "for many, the pursuit of happiness means living free of regret and future worries." DLE says (20:01) "They just have so much to teach us about taking one day at a time." According to the narrator (31:40), "For Everett, the detail about how Pirahã culture affects grammar lies in their fixation with the present. This preoccupation, he claims, produces a grammar with only present tense, a grammar without recursion, a grammar of happiness." Of course, at least in the subtitles, the film does show Pirahã talking about the future and the past. Traits that are not uncommon in Amazonian languages, such as lack of numeral elaboration and absence of tense marking on verbs, are presented as unique discoveries.

²⁴ Both Novaes and Saldanha are honest, intelligent men carrying on the type of work of their distinguished fathers, Washinton Novaes and Luiz Carlos Saldanha, respectively.

²⁵ <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=5NyB4fIZHeU> (December 22, 2025)

²⁶ <https://hd-documentarios.blogspot.com/2014/05/lingua-piraha-o-codigo-do-amazonas.html> (03/08/2026)

²⁷ Pedro Novaes furnished excellent, detailed information, which agrees with relevant documents, in various contacts with me: Google Meet, November 19, 2024, WhatsApp November 20, 21 and 23, 2024, and WhatsApp January 27, 2025.

The first half of the film spends considerable time on DLE's claimed change from Christian missionary to atheist. This is presented as a noble spiritual journey, with no embarrassing mention of his activities to combat the evil spirits said to possess the Pirahã nor the filmstrips about Jesus. These activities appear to have continued for years after his claimed loss of faith. It is all about *him*, with no description of native spiritual beliefs nor awareness of the possible ill effects on Pirahã self esteem, cultural continuity and social organization if he had been able to convince them that the beliefs of their ancestors were satanic.

The film repeatedly proclaims the amazing scientific importance of DLE's research on the Pirahã and its grave threat to Chomskyan theory. Early in the film, the narrator intones, portentously (0:16), "Deep in the Amazon rainforest, there is a people who could transform our understanding of human language." Some brief interviews, apparently filmed after the second trip of the filmmakers to Brazil, are interspersed with other content, to give a feeling of drama, prestige and irresistible controversy. These include John Searle, Steven Pinker, Tom Roeser and Noam Chomsky.

A new phase of the film begins (20:30) with a scene of sailboats on a river and the subtitle "BOSTON 2011." The narrator says, "It's been two years since Everett's last visit to the Amazon." That sentence is true: the filmmaker's trip with DLE to the Pirahã was in 2009. However, the following statements about an expedition led by Ted Gibson (coeditor of DLE's 2024 festschrift) are all false:

- "At MIT Brain and Cognitive Sciences Lab a new expedition is preparing to go and test his claims."
- "This expedition will be the largest and perhaps most rigorous to test Daniel Everett's ideas. In the eyes of many, its results may well settle the debate."
- "Everett will accompany the team as translator."

What seemed initially puzzling when investigating these claims was that there is no record of an authorization for such an expedition in the files of the AAEP, and DLE would be a doubtful participant, given his exclusion from Sauerland's authorization in 2008. When consulted, Pedro Novaes explained what really happened.

The filmmakers wanted to return to the Pirahã to collect more footage. Their first plan was to accompany the expedition of Ted Gibson. However, Gibson's request for approval to the Coordenação Geral de Cooperação Internacional of the CNPq, with Miguel Oliveira as its Brazilian sponsor (file number 002379/2010-4), was rejected by two ad hoc referees in 2010. Oliveira appealed, as was his right, but the second referee judgements were once again negative. Novaes' account is confirmed by documents obtained from the CNPq. The second rejection of the Gibson-Oliveira project was communicated to Oliveira in a letter dated March 31, 2011.²⁸ So, clearly, the filmmakers, Gibson and DLE knew four months before filming the Boston scenes in July, 2011 that the project would not be implemented and simply pretended otherwise. This explains why there was no authorization in the AAEP files for the Gibson project: it was turned down by the CNPq and was therefore not forwarded to the FUNAI.

Furthermore, the project was not the largest project aimed at the Pirahã, being considerably smaller than the proposal of Sauerland in 2008. The 2010 project was focused on numbers, not on general syntax. The description of the aborted Gibson project, entitled "Origins of numeral competence: Assessment of numerical concepts in Pirahã," obtained from the

²⁸ Copy supplied by Maria Antonia Pimentel of CNPq in an e-mail to Moore November 30, 2024

CNPq,²⁹ includes, as researchers going to the Pirahã, Edward Albert Fletcher Gibson, Michael Christensen Frank, Evelina Fedorenko and Steven Thomas Piantadosi, with Miguel Oliveira as the Brazilian coordinator. DLE was not included. So it was not clear to referees who would translate for the project, aside from its other problems.

The next episode in the film is a scene (33:34) with a subtitle “BOSTON AUGUST 2011,” with DLE packing a suitcase, apparently to go on Ted Gibson’s (non-existent) expedition. Then the drama begins. The narrator says, “On the eve of his departure, Everett gets a call from Brazil’s National Indian Foundation, known as FUNAI.” DLE answers the phone in Portuguese, “Olá, Pedro, tudo bem?” Then he continues in English, “Yeah, man, I think it’s gonna be extre... I don’t think, I know...it’s going to be extremely disappointing to Ted and his team. Yeah, I don’t know how I am going to deal with it.” Then he hangs up and looks into the camera, with an air of sad exasperation, and explains,

“I was just told that, after all this planning and all this effort and having gone down, that Valmir, the local FUNAI supervisor, has said that we can’t go back to the village. I don’t know what is going to happen, but the only thing I can do is fly all the way down to Brazil, go talk to Valmir and say, you know, ‘What can we do to make this happen?’”

Clearly, the scene is staged, unless the film crew took up residence in DLE’s house, waiting for the phone call. There are two obvious problems with this scene. The first is that Gibson’s project could not have been blocked by anyone in the FUNAI, since it did not exist, having been rejected by the CNPq, as we have seen above. The second is that the regional authority does not have the power to block a project if it has been approved by the AAEP and the president of the FUNAI. If the AAEP did not approve it, then the problem is there, not in the regional authority. The “Pedro” of the phone call would be Pedro Novaes, who handled the authorization process with the FUNAI in Brasília.³⁰ Once again, Novaes clarifies what really happened. He never made the phone call and the whole scene is fake, probably filmed after the film crew returned to the USA from their second trip to Brazil, when they had footage of Valmir Parintintin to concoct the story about his blocking the (nonexistent) project, blockage which never happened.

The new plan for the film was to try to get DLE authorized as part of the film crew, as was done for his 2009 authorization. DLE would go to Porto Velho in the western state of Rondônia with part of the film crew and wait for the authorization to come through so that they could go to the regional authority in Humaitá, about 200 kilometers to the north of Porto Velho, Rondônia, check in with local FUNAI office, and proceed from there by boat to the Pirahã.

In Brasília, Novaes finally managed a meeting with the president of FUNAI, Márcio Meira, arranged by a mutual friend. However, Meira said it was “politically impossible” to authorize DLE. That is understandable, since DLE had a record of repeated unauthorized research visits to indigenous areas and the MPF was vigilant because the local FUNAI had let DLE slip through for years. The outcome of Novaes’ efforts were that the FUNAI in Brasília authorized the film crew to go to the Pirahã but not DLE, notifying the regional center in Humaitá of this. Learning that he would not be authorized, DLE filmed two fake scenes in Porto Velho and then went to Brasília, where he filmed some more scenes with Novaes. Novaes then went to Porto Velho and joined the film crew and they went to Humaitá. There they filmed some scenes with Valmir, the

²⁹ E-mail from Maria Antonia Pimentel of CNPq to Moore, November 30, 2024

³⁰ Novaes has retained his e-mails from the time of the film and is sure of what he says.

superintendent, before traveling on by boat to the Pirahã to film more there. DLE returned to the USA from Brasília. The film crew went to the USA at some point to film the interviews and some scenes with DLE.

After the staged telephone call to DLE, the film proceeds, presenting a fictive narrative in western Brazil. The scene switches to the city of Humaitá with a shot of the front of the regional FUNAI office (34:12) in a placid setting. The regional FUNAI administrator, Valmir Parintintin, is shown stamping documents (dated 28 August 2011), and the narrator intones, “With just one stamp, Valmir can authorize the entrance of Everett.” This is false; he needs the authorization from the central FUNAI in Brasília to accompany the film crew, which was denied. The issue has inexplicably shifted from the authorization of Gibson’s (nonexistent) project, which did not include DLE in any case, to DLE himself. Valmir speaks some about missionaries. He never directly states that DLE cannot enter the Pirahã territory. At one point there is a voice-over in which there are a couple of jumbled sentences that seem to indicate DLE has a problem because being a missionary: “O Daniel tem unh...os Pirahã gostam dele...a gente percebe que os Pirahã gostam...Mas temos uma preocupação ...uh, da ameaça diretamente à cultura Pirahã...é...uh..a questão dos missionários, né?” [“Daniel has...unh...The Pirahã like him...one perceives that the Pirahã like him... But today we have a concern...about the threat directly to the Pirahã culture...uh... The question of missionaries, right?”]³¹

Novaes filmed the scenes with Valmir in Humaitá but does not recall specifics of what was said. He observes that it is easy to edit sound, juxtaposing stretches in a voice-over to give an impression of connected discourse. He said that Valmir never blocked DLE on the basis of his being a missionary. This is confirmed by an official communication³² in which Valmir has clearly absorbed DLE’s claim that he became an atheist and is no longer a missionary:

O lingüista Daniel Everett desenvolveu intenso trabalho sobre a língua do povo Pirahã, sendo hoje uma das maiores autoridades na área. Afirma que, em consequência do profundo envolvimento com os Pirahã e conhecimento de sua cultura, rompeu com a missão e com a sua ex-esposa (Karen Everett), tornando-se ateu e passando a desenvolver um trabalho diferente dos objetivos dos missionários. Atualmente os Pirahã, com acompanhamento da FUNAI, autorizam a empresa Sertão Filmes a coletar imagens para produção do filme “A gramática da felicidade”, acerca do controverso trabalho do linguista Daniel Everett, mas não se trata de pesquisa; o filme está em parte final de produção e provavelmente será lançado no próximo ano.

The Linguist Daniel Everett has developed extensive work on the language of the Pirahã people, and is today one of the leading authorities in the field. He claims that, as a result of his deep involvement with the Pirahã and knowledge of their culture, he broke with the mission and his ex-wife (Karen Everett), becoming an atheist and pursuing a work that differs from the missionaries’ objectives. Currently, the Pirahã, with the supervision of FUNAI have authorized the company Sertão Filmes to collect footage for

³¹The subtitles insert ‘really’ before “like” to show great fondness, and the last sentence in the subtitles is translated as, “But one of the greatest threats to Pirahã culture today are the missionaries.” One wonders about the translations of Pirahã, which are difficult to check.

³²Ofício no 149/GAB/FUNAI/CR-MADEIRA/2012, responding to Dr. Elli Francisco Zatti Faccioni’s OFÍCIO no. 311/2012/5o OFÍCIO CÍVEL/PR/AM/SEC-EXT 12, document contained in MPF dossier (Inquérito Civil 1.31.000.000601/2007- 75)

the production of the film "The Grammar of Happiness," about the controversial work of linguist Daniel Everett. However, this is not research; the film is in the final stages of production and will likely be released next year.]

The film moves on to a scene of DLE (35:12) driving a car, saying "I'm on my way to Humaitá, Amazonas, to meet with Valmir Parintintin. Valmir is the one who has the power to say whether I can or can't go back to the village right now." In fact, according to Novaes, DLE stayed in Porto Velho and never went to Humaitá and the scene is fake. Then he is on a boat and the narrator (35:44) says, "Everett suspects that his missionary past is not the sole reason for his rejection. The real cause, he believes, is his collision with the linguistics establishment." (This makes no sense—was Valmir in cahoots with Chomsky?) DLE (35:59) claims, "A couple of years ago a couple of US linguists wrote a letter to the National Indian Foundation accusing me of conducting racist research."

Next, DLE is said by the narrator to be in Humaitá but is informed that Valmir had traveled and would not be back for a fortnight. DLE appears, on the street, (36:25), very vexed, and exclaims, "He is not there! I come all this way and he is not even there!" This is also fake, filmed in Porto Velho, which explains why DLE is not shown talking to the FUNAI staff or the substitute superintendent in Humaitá.

There is a shorter version of the film,³³ which eliminates about five minutes of the longer version. In it, the part of the film which shows Valmir Parintintin and then (supposedly) DLE in Humaitá is deleted. In this shortened version DLE gets the telephone call with the bad news and says that he is going to Brazil to speak to Valmir to work something out. But then he is next shown in an airport and going to the University of Brasília. He does not go to speak to Valmir. Some voice-overs from the parts that were eliminated are retained. A male voice does the narration in this shorter version.

In the longer version of the film, DLE (supposedly) leaves Humaitá and then is shown going to Brasília, supposedly to appeal (appeal what?) to the president of the FUNAI. While there, he gives a lecture in the Department of Indigenous Languages (in fact, the Laboratory of Indigenous Languages, LALI, a small group). However, hardly anyone shows up. This is claimed to be caused by a boycott by the Chomskyan Department of Linguistics. DLE (37:27) says, into the camera, in a confidential manner, "I've just been informed that the main linguistics department here at the university has decided, once again, to boycott my talk because it's critical of their theory." Professor Aryon Rodrigues (37:46) says, in a hushed tone, that "The department here is strongly generative (Chomskyan). They won't even discuss." Professor Ana Suelly Cabral (38:43) piles on conspiracy theory, stating, "Some of the linguists that criticize Dan Everett went to FUNAI to try to deter his entrance into indigenous areas."

There are two problems with the explanation of the sparse audience. First, not even the linguists of the main department who work with indigenous languages, none of whom are "Chomskyan," appeared. Second, it was not unusual for attendance at LALI events to be low. It had nothing to do with DLE's supposed theoretical revelations. Aryon Rodrigues was making

³³ [https://daneverettbooks.com/wp-content/uploads/2024/03/The%20Grammar%20of%20Happiness\(Full%20Episode\).mp4](https://daneverettbooks.com/wp-content/uploads/2024/03/The%20Grammar%20of%20Happiness(Full%20Episode).mp4)
(03/08/2026)

aggressive moves in the politics of indigenous linguistics in Brazil in this epoch. Moore and Galucio (2016) describe his xenophobic attempt to block international documentation programs in Brazil, after one of the programs turned down his application for funding. As the Brazilian coordinator of Sauerland's 2008 project with the Pirahã, Aryon Rodrigues had to face Claudio Romero and certainly knew of DLE's illegality and his expulsion from the Pirahã in 2007, which were the real cause of his problems with the FUNAI. Those problems had nothing to do with Chomsky. However, mutual support was useful for both DLE and Aryon Rodrigues at this time and so Rodrigues and Cabral collaborated with the Persecution Hoax for the film.

All the contacts for the film with the FUNAI in Brasília were handled by Pedro Novaes. There was never a request by DLE to meet with the president of FUNAI, nor any denial of such a request. The denial of Gibson's project was done by the CNPq months earlier. But the film presents another fake telephone call from Pedro (39:13), after which DLE indignantly denounces an imagined conspiracy:

"I can't go back. These people have refused to meet with me. They have refused to talk to me. They have refused to let me go there and present my views. All of this takes place behind closed doors in meetings that I'm not allowed to be at, with people saying things about me that I am not allowed to respond to! It is cowardly!"

None of this was true—pure conspiracy fiction. It reaches a level of calumny that would not endear DLE to the FUNAI nor be propitious for future cooperation. In fact, access to the AAEP, the sector which handles research authorizations for the FUNAI, is open to the relevant public. All DLE would have had to do was ask the FUNAI building receptionist which floor the sector was on and then take the elevator there. One can imagine the AAEP staff's reaction.

In the film, DLE records a melodramatic message to the Pirahã, blaming FUNAI for the fact that he would not be returning. The scene changes to the Brain and Cognitive Sciences lab at MIT, then back to Brazil, where the film crew is shown arriving in small boats with the Pirahã. They are surprised to find that the Pequiá village in the Pirahã reserve now has a health clinic, toilets, permanent houses, electricity generated by a generator and a school, where children are learning Portuguese and learning to count. That is, the Brazilian government bestowed upon them the things that a rural Brazilian community would want, in spite of the differences in needs. Compare this to the analysis of needs and urgent measures in 1.0 above. There are mixed opinions among the Pirahã as to the advantages and disadvantages of the government's largess. DLE speaks about the challenges, but has no analysis of needs nor of measures to take, saying that "My bet is that they're going to stay strong. But I could be wrong." The scene goes back to the MIT laboratory and then ends back with the Pirahã.

The above rather detailed fact-finding of the film is part of the fact-finding of GKP's claims about DLE in Brazil, since GKP appears to have adopted information from the film — for example, the false claims about trying to talk to the president of the FUNAI. As was shown above, the film assembled fake scene after fake scene to create a completely false narrative in which DLE is a hero of true science, victimized by bigoted officials and devious doctrinaire linguists.

This is the familiar Persecution Hoax in cinematic form. In this way, DLE covers up the real reasons for his problems with the FUNAI, promotes himself, and smears Noam Chomsky, linguists in Brazil and honest Brazilian government officials. Given the exotic nature (for foreigners) of Amazonia and the difficult access to information, judging by comments on the

film's website, most viewers of the film seem to be influenced to praise DLE, disdain Chomsky and believe in a simple present-only Pirahã wonderland. Some examples:³⁴

@CrookedRoadMusic: Thanks for posting this! I enjoyed it greatly. Very interesting that some "intellectual heavyweights" who are supposed to be paragons of academic open-mindedness exhibit religious zealotry in "defense" of their theory, which is to say no defense at all save blanket denial or accusations. Shame on Noam Chomsky for his egotistical close-mindedness. And three cheers for Daniel Everett and the Pirahã and all the open-minded academics who are doing great work.

@suku16: The way the scientific community treats a fellow scientist is shameful. This is not science. A real scientist would know that theories aren't forever. It's extremely arrogant to presume that we know the definitive answer to any question. The search for knowledge is never over.

@mukundmolekule; These people are innocent and peaceful in their own way please don't pollute them in the name civilization. Let them live where ever they are with their own style.

The film has perhaps been as effective in influencing linguists as in influencing the general public. One example of this is Stefan Müller, the Chief Editor of the book series *Empirically Oriented Theoretical Morphology and Syntax* of the Language Science Press. In the preface (Müller 2024) to DLE's festschrift he characterizes the anarchists' principles and then says, "But what is described in the movie *Grammar of Happiness* (O'Neill & Wood 2012) and even more clearly in Pullum (2024), Chapter 2 of this volume, is exactly the opposite." (p. ix) He recounts his discovery of the film: "I learned about the movie *Grammar of Happiness* from my late colleague Gisbert Fanselow, one of the best German grammarians, who also worked in MGG. He told me that he was watching the movie with his students during the last lecture before Christmas. Then I started doing the same." (p. xii). So Müller swallowed the cinematic version of the Persecution Hoax whole and found it delicious: "I thank Dan Everett for being the topic of my Christmas movie. I must have watched it at least 20 times by now."

8. Toward an accurate history of indigenous linguistics in Brazil

The main goal of this paper is to provide facts for people to have a basis for understanding the events discussed. If anyone has contrary facts, they should put them up. In case of doubt about who is telling the truth, the ethics committee of the Brazilian Anthropological Association (ABA) has the capacity to judge the facts. As in the case of Chagnon/Tierney, the facts make it reasonably clear what really happened in the case of DLE in Brazil: whose accusations are true, whose are false and who created fictions.

This information is useful for a factual understanding of the history of Amazonian linguistics, which has progressed rapidly in this century. The history of this is a large topic, but one can investigate and describe parts of the picture. To continue the advance of the study of indigenous languages in Brazil it is important to explain to potential researchers what really are the rules and procedures and what are the consequences of not following them.

³⁴<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=5NyB4fIZHeU> (December 27, 2025)

What are the historical facts? GKP states that “In writing this paper I have confirmed claims about specific people’s actions and statements from suitable sources or personal reminiscences as far as that was possible” (Pullum 2024b: 68). That is doubtful. For example, the three documents, mentioned in Section 5 above as posted to Facebook, that show DLE’s lack of research authorization and his expulsion from the Pirahã reserve, are brushed off as “remarks.” (Pullum 2024b: 38) Aikhenvald’s statement dismissing the value of the SIL work on Pirahã, in Section 6 above, was altered and given a different interpretation. Chernela’s description of extensive anthropological research that disagrees with DLE’s peculiar claims about Pirahã thought and culture (Section 7.1 above) are not mentioned in GKP’s account of her views. Of the 36 people GKP thanks for contributing their time to improving his paper (Pullum 2024b: 69), none of them are Latin Americans and only one has experience in Amazonia. This lack is problematic, not for being politically incorrect or even being undiplomatic. It is problematic because it avoids relevant information from the people and documents that would show what the reality was, puncturing the bubble. This paper aims to correct that.

9. Broader view and some linguistic fieldwork observations

The study of Amazonian languages is advancing steadily in terms of analysis and description of languages, theoretical studies of various types, diachrony and linguistic prehistory, language and culture relations, digital documentation and its infrastructure, language revitalization, training indigenous students in linguistics and documentation and literacy in the native language. Parts of GKP’s linguistic discussions contain points that reasonable people can agree on and are relevant for the direction of Amazonian linguistics. His (2024b) sections 4 and 5 are useful for showing the handicaps of the field methods DLE used in the Pirahã (p. 55): “What Everett discovered in later years was that the Pirahã had regularly been saying ‘Yes’ to his occasional ‘Can-you-say-this-S?’ questions just to humor him, even if the S was decidedly unidiomatic.”

In his discussion, GKP rejects arguments which aim to show recursion in Pirahã syntax. While not taking sides in this debate, I suspect that he (Pullum 2024b: 63) is right in doubting alleged nested PPs in Pirahã. The structures which translate as PPs in the language of the Gavião of Rondônia (Moore 1984) and in the language of the Tiriyo (Meira 1999), for example, do not occur as attributives inside NPs and do not nest. This is not uncommon in Amazonian languages and can generally be demonstrated by simple syntactic tests; there was no need to spend decades to come to this conclusion, whether or not it is correct.

GKP concludes (Pullum 2023b: 66) that “No one should claim, in the present state of our knowledge, that we have a good understanding of the syntax of Pirahã (or for that matter any other language, even Standard English.” A reasonable takeaway from this discussion is that it is unwise to make extravagant theoretical claims on the basis of precarious, under-analyzed data. It is certainly essential to train young Amazonian linguists in appropriate field methods and intelligent analytic techniques, to obtain better data and analysis.

However, GKP doesn’t advocate better field methods and data analysis. Rather, he states that the study of Pirahã syntax depends on collaborations with people who “are prepared to spend time paying close attention to everyday usage in the Pirahã speech community.” (p. 66) This would promote missionaries, who invest heavily in field presence and language learning in their lengthy work of replacing native belief systems with their own. In fact, he lists five possible collaborators: Steve Sheldon (a SIL member for 58 years), DLE’s ex-wife, Keren, and his

three children. However, it is not clear how this collaboration would work or if any of the five have interest and availability. None of them has ever had a scientific (non-missionary) research approval from the CNPq and it is naïve to think that they ever will. Aikhenvald's (2012) low opinion of the SIL linguistic work on Pirahã argues against these as collaborators. Speaking a language and spending a long time in the community does not guarantee correct analysis and description.

A more reasonable suggestion would be to imitate the methodology of successful descriptions, for example, the 1006-page description of the language of the Hup (predominantly monolingual hunters and gatherers) by Patience Epps (2008)³⁵ or the 731-page description of the language of the Tiriýó by Sérgio Meira (1999),³⁶ who worked in a basically monolingual manner. Though both of these linguists speak the language that they study,³⁷ the quality of the analysis and description is from sound field methods, including a collection of a variety of texts, their careful analysis (without English bias), the formation of hypotheses and the testing of the hypotheses, preferably in the field. Both works were completed during affiliation with the Linguistics Division of the Museu Goeldi in Belém, Pará, Brazil. Other affiliates include Spike Gildea,³⁸ Adam Singerman³⁹ and Julien Meyer.⁴⁰ In addition to their scientific work, these linguists undertake practical projects for native communities and participate in the training of Brazilian linguists. They enjoy warm cooperative relations with Brazilian scholars and occupy a positive place in the history of Brazilian indigenous linguistics, which they are helping to develop. These are examples of the kind of visiting researchers that are desirable for Brazil, not the GTDAR types nor SIL missionaries.

Acknowledgments:

Many people have generously given their time to furnish evidence for this article. Only a few can be mentioned. A dynamic defender of indigenous rights and well-being, Daniel Dalberto, a *Procurador da República* of the Ministério Público Federal, provided access to the voluminous dossier about Daniel Everett in the MPF. He follows the situation of the Pirahã and called attention to the two FUNAI reports on their condition, cited in the article.

Members of the staff of the Coordenação-Geral de Povos Indígenas Isolados e de Recente Contato of the FUNAI in Brasília supplied useful orientation for navigating the system for Solicitação de Informação ao Cidadão (SIC – Citizen's Information Request). The person who originally explained to me the utility of SICs for checking the true, documented history of FUNAI research authorizations and related matters was the great *sertanista* Bruno Pereira, when he was the coordinator of the sector.

Uli Sauerland kindly provided a document and explanation about his research project among the Pirahã and DLE's removal from it. His account agrees with documents from the FUNAI and what I observed of Cláudio Romero's opinion of DLE. This period, between DLE's 2007 expulsion from the Pirahã reserve and his 2011 film activities, was little known. But now the pieces of the puzzle fit together.

³⁵ Panini Award, 2007, also Kenneth L. Hale Award 2020

³⁶ Mary R. Haas Award, 2000

³⁷ Meira is an accomplished polyglot who speaks about twenty languages, including Tiriýó.

³⁸ Mary R. Haas Award, 1993

³⁹ Mary R Haas Book Award, 2020

⁴⁰ Rolex Award, 2006

Maria Antônia Pimentel and Juceliton Santos Matos of the Coordenação Geral de Cooperação Internacional of the Conselho Nacional de Desenvolvimento Científico e Tecnológico (CNPq) provided documents and information. Sra. Maria Antônia was not amused by the misrepresentation of the research authorization process in the Persecution Hoax. In the most brazen example, brought to her attention, Everett's film omitted the fact that her staff had conducted a fair, reasoned judgement of Ted Gibson's proposal for research among the Pirahã in 2010 and it was turned down by ad hoc referees of the scientific community. Instead, the film falsely claims that there was an impediment created by a missionary-intolerant regional FUNAI administrator (Valmir Parintintin) and perpetuated by a Chomskyan cabal in central FUNAI headquarters in Brasília. We agreed that this false account should be explained to the public.

Pedro Novaes, the Brazilian director of Everett's film, was forthcoming and objective in providing information about how it was made. The information created an initial shock, but it was confirmed by documents and other information. Again, with more information, the pieces of the puzzle fit together. As far as I know, Novaes is completely honest, in contrast to the film.

Pattie Epps provided comments on a manuscript of the article, as did my two colleagues at the Linguistics Division of the Museu Goeldi, Hein van der Voort and Ana Vilacy Galucio (both of whom have always done everything possible for the indigenous groups with whom they work). These three do not necessarily agree with the ideas expressed nor with the style of the article.

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